

Tussle between power, skill and temperament in ‘Group of Death’

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Unlike the other three groups of this T20 World Cup, where lopsided odds present clear favourites for the Super 8, Group D has more than two contenders.

On paper, South Africa might appear as the heavyweight, but underestimating Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, and the Netherlands, which has beaten the Proteas in the last two World Cups, would be fraught with risk for Aiden Markram's side.

The addition of Nepal makes Group D the most competitive pool.

South Africa is batting its way to victory

South Africa has laid its cards on the table for how it will approach the tournament. In Markram, Heinrich Klaasen, Tristan Stubbs, and David Miller, the Proteas have had four batters with a strike rate of over 150 in T20Is since 2022.

The latest inductee into this slam-bang batting order is Ryan Rickelton. The 27-year-old southpaw, yet to get a cap in the shortest format, stole the show in SA20 2024, where he scored 530 runs in 10 innings at a strike rate above 173.

Three of South Africa's four group games will be in the USA, which is expected to have batter-friendly tracks, giving the batters a chance to flex their might with the



willow.

With the ball, South Africa again turned to the SA20 when it included Ottneil Baartman, the highest wicket-taker of the 2024 edition. However, he might have to wait for his turn in a pace battery that boasts Anrich Nortje, Kagiso Rabada, Marco Jansen, and Gerald Coetzee.

Keshav Maharaj, Tabraiz Shamsi, and Bjorn Fortuin will be waiting to pounce once low and slow tracks in the Caribbean come the team's way.

If South Africa wants to banish the ghosts of the shock loss to the